

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

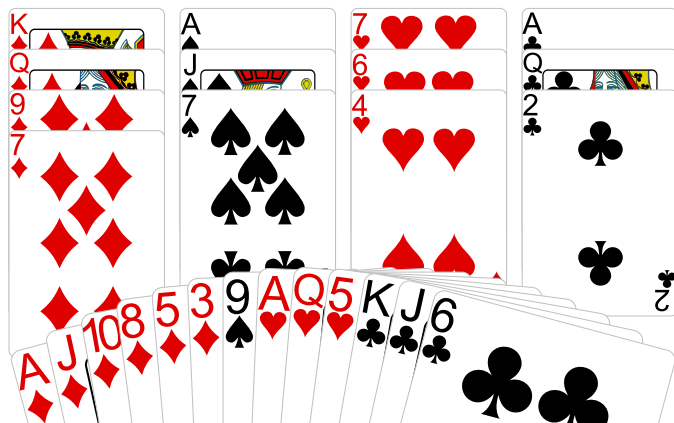
The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

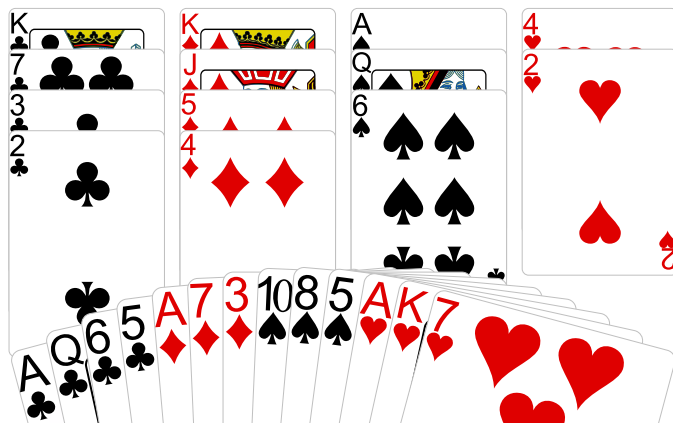
You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Deal 1 Ctr: 6♦ Goal: at most ____ losers



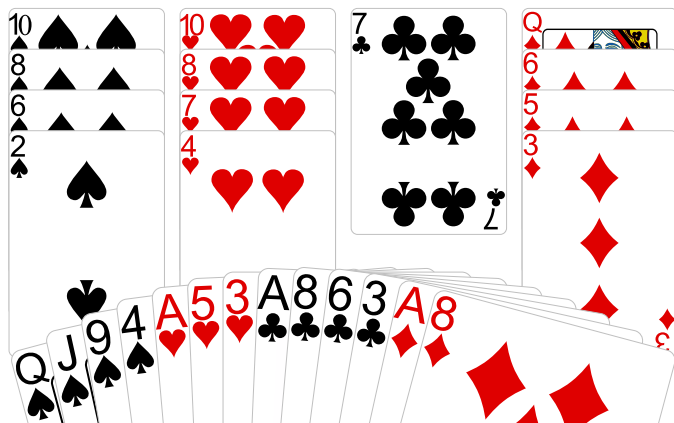
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



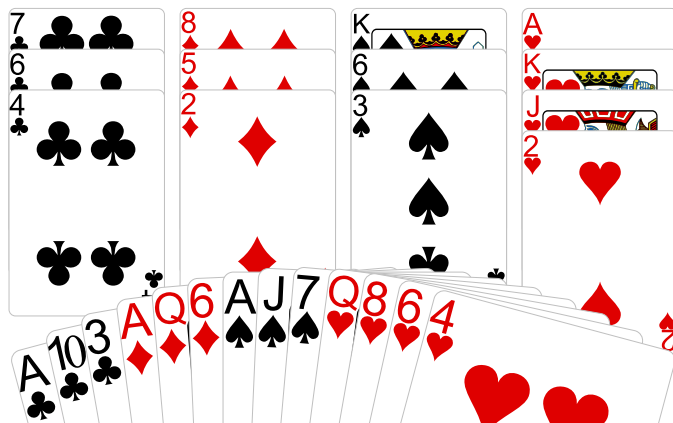
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 2♠ Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6 

Declarer: North

Board: 2

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 2 

Declarer: South

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4 

Declarer: North

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 8 6 5 3

♥ J T 9 3

♦ 6 2

♣ 9 7 4

♠ 9

♥ A Q 5

♦ A J T 8 5 3

♣ K J 6



♠ K Q T 4 2

♥ K 8 2

♦ 4

♣ T 8 5 3

♠ A J 7

♥ 7 6 4

♦ K Q 9 7

♣ A Q 2

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	4♥	Pass	4♠
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			
6♦ by North			

With 17 points and a 6-card suit you are definitely thinking about slam. The way to suggest slam to partner is to jump in a suit, so you bid 3♦.

Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

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Typically you start showing controls, up the line. So you bid 4♥, showing the ♥A. Partner then bids 4♠.

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Partner says 4♦, bypassing 3NT and agreeing to your suit;

Typically you start showing controls, up the line. So you bid 4♥, showing the ♥A. Partner then bids 4♠.

When partner shows first round ♠ control you know you don't have two quick losers, so you bid 6♦.

North plays 6♦. East leads the ♠K. You win East's opening lead with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

You only have one too many losers, and you have a very obvious finesse for the ♥K. But first you pull trumps in two rounds. Do you take the ♥ finesse now?

No you don't. In fact you won't need to take it at all, not with that very valuable ♠J in dummy.

Play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q, then ruff the ♠7 in your hand. Next play ♣K, then another ♣ to dummy's ♣A. Play the ♠J from dummy and discard your ♥5. East will win this trick, (from the opening lead you knew he had the ♠Q), but he will be end-played. A ♠ or a ♣ will give you a ruff/sluff, but a ♥ will give you a free finesse into your ♥A Q.

There is no doubt that a finesse will save a contract for you sometimes.

Sometimes being about 50% of the time on average.

So whenever you see your contract depending on a finesse, just look again and see if perhaps an elimination play is available.

Board 2
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A Q 6
♥ 4 2
♦ K J 5 4
♣ K 7 3 2

♠ K 7 3
♥ Q J 9 8 6 5
♦ Q 8 6 2
♣ -



♠ T 8 5
♥ A K 7
♦ A 7 3
♣ A Q 6 5

♠ J 9 4 2
♥ T 3
♦ T 9
♣ J T 9 8 4

West	North	East	South
	2♥	2NT	Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

♣A . . . and North discards a ♦!

Over an opponent's Weak 2-bid a 2NT overcall is used to show basically the same as a 1NT opening bid, but promising stopper(s) in their suit.

Partner bids 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥10. As expected, South leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 8

You need only one more winner; the best chance will be a 3-2 split in ♣s. But if that doesn't happen you might have to try the finesse in either ♠s or ♦s. The problem is that both finesses go into the North hand. Because of that fact there is no reason to hold up on the first trick so you win the ♥A. Then you play the

Don't be sad that the ♣s didn't split, your contract is now guaranteed! Well, guaranteed as long as North has only a 6-card ♥ suit.

Play your ♥K, and when South follows suit play your ♥7. North wins this trick and he can also win 3 more ♥ tricks. But when he runs out of ♥s he will be forced to play a ♠ or a ♦ because he doesn't have any ♣s. Either one will give you your ninth trick.

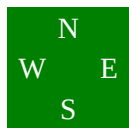
If the ♣s had split 4-1 you wouldn't know it until you played a second ♣.

But it wouldn't matter, you would still play the same way. As long as you can strip North of any ♣s you can make the throw-in.

Board 3
 South Deals
 None Vul

♠ K 7 3
 ♥ K 9 2
 ♦ T 7 4
 ♣ K Q J 4

♠ T 8 6 2
 ♥ T 8 7 4
 ♦ Q 6 5 3
 ♣ 7



♠ A 5
 ♥ Q J 6
 ♦ K J 9 2
 ♣ T 9 5 2

♠ Q J 9 4
 ♥ A 5 3
 ♦ A 8
 ♣ A 8 6 3

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
All Pass			
2♠ by South			

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 8

That is a lot of losers. But it makes the plan that much easier. You will try to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can, and you will do that by ruffing ♣s.

Win the ♣A and ruff a ♣ in dummy. Return to your hand with the ♦A and ruff another ♣. Back to your hand with the ♥A and ruff another ♣.

You have taken 6 tricks already and cannot be prevented from winning two more trumps.

Making those small trumps by ruffing was a pretty obvious play.

Lucky for you the defenders didn't see the advantage of playing three rounds of trumps right off the bat.

It would be tough for West to come up with a ♠ lead from ♠ K 7 3, but it would have been great defense.

You have a bad hand. Bad, bad, bad hand. But you think playing in ♠s, ♥s or ♦s would be better than playing 1NT. Can you get partner to bid one of those suits? Sure, you just say 2♣. Partner says 2♠. Your call.

You have a bad hand. Bad, bad, bad hand. But you think playing in ♠s, ♥s or ♦s would be better than playing 1NT. Can you get partner to bid one of those suits? Sure, you just say 2♣. Partner says 2♠. Your call.

Your dream just came true. So pass and it won't turn into a nightmare.

The contract would be 2♠ played by North.

South plays 2♠. West leads the ♣K.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 7
 ♥ Q 8 6 4
 ♦ A Q 6
 ♣ A T 3

♠ Q 8 2

♥ 9

♦ K 9 7 4

♣ K Q J 9 2



♠ K 6 3

♥ A K J 2

♦ 8 5 2

♣ 7 6 4

♠ T 9 5 4

♥ T 7 5 3

♦ J T 3

♣ 8 5

West

1NT

All Pass

3NT by West

both cases the finesse would be into the North hand so the question of disrupting opponent's communications doesn't arise - South is not going to get the lead.

North

Pass

East

3NT

South

Holding a 4-card ♥ suit some bidders would use Stayman. However, when you have 4-3-3-3 distribution there is little chance of ruffing so others prefer not to use Stayman. You take the latter view and bid 3NT with your 11 points.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♣K and South follows with the ♣5.

Do you hold up? If so, how many times?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

Your ninth trick will be either the ♠J or the ♦Q. In both cases the finesse would be into the North hand so the question of disrupting opponent's communications doesn't arise - South is not going to get the lead.

Nonetheless it is a good idea to hold up - **but only once**.

North then plays the ♣Q which you win as South follows. Next you run four ♥ tricks, ending in dummy. You play dummy's ♠K, your sixth trick so far. It is crunch time. Do you now finesse for the ♦K or the ♠Q?

The answer is NO, you do not take either finesse. Instead you play a ♣, hoping North must take the trick. And he does. North then cashes two more ♣ tricks but then he is out of ♣s. Since he is also out of ♥s he is going to have to play either a ♠ or a ♦, either one of which will make you very happy!

The reason for holding up on the first ♣ but taking the second was to keep your options open for the endplay.

If South had not followed to the second ♣ you might not have been able to use the endplay. Instead you would have run the ♥s, and if North did not discard a ♣, you would have to guess as to which finesse to try. With the cards as shown neither would have worked.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ J T 5
♥ Q J T 2
♦ Q 5 4
♣ K 8 6

♠ A 6

♥ K 7 4

♦ A J 9 3

♣ A 9 7 4



♠ 7 3

♥ A 9 5 3

♦ 8 7 6

♣ Q J T 2

♠ K Q 9 8 4 2

♥ 8 6

♦ K T 2

♣ 5 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			
4♠ by North			

Partner transfers and you naturally respond 2♠.

Partner bids the ♠ game and you pass.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣Q. West plays the ♣8 and your first decision is whether to hold up.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

You should certainly hold up. West is the Danger hand here because if West ever gets the lead he can play a ♥ through your unprotected ♥K, possibly giving you two ♥ losers. If you take the first trick with the ♣A you open the door for West to gain entry with the ♣K which you know he has.

Next pull three rounds of trumps. Fortune smiles and they split 3-2.

Now it's time to play on ♦s. Do you finesse for the ♦Q? and if so, which way do you finesse?

Missing 6 ♦s to the Queen of course you should finesse. And you will finesse through West, of course, because he is the Danger Hand. So play dummy's ♦K, then play the ♦10 and let it ride.

This time West holds the ♦Q and you make an overtrick, winning 4 ♦ tricks and discarding a ♥ loser from dummy.

Another time East will hold the ♦Q and you will make the contract, but no overtrick.